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150 MILLION USERS PUNISHED: TELEGRAM FOUNDER

Govt bans Telegram until June 22 in bid to ‘secure’ NEET retest

Platform told to disable editing of messages posted until June 30

Soumyarendra Barik & Abhinaya Harigovind
New Delhi, June 16

THE GOVERNMENT Tuesday temporarily blocked Telegram, a popular messaging application, until June 22, after the platform's "non-responsiveness" in aiding the ongoing probe into the May 3 NEET-UG paper leak and for curbing the spread of fraudulent claims of access to the June 21 re-examination paper by handles on the platform, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Telegram is among the most popular personal messaging applications in the country, with an estimated 150 million users, behind only Meta's WhatsApp, which has over 500 million users.

Pavel Durov, founder of the Telegram messaging app, said that by temporarily banning Telegram in the country, the Indian authorities have "punished" over 150 million ordinary users in India.

The ban has not stopped

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Kota is the hub for NEET preparations. PARUL KULSHRESTHA

BILATERAL TALKS WITH U.S. PRESIDENT TODAY

Trump listening, Modi tells G7: Shortage of trust, need to rebuild

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 16

UNDERLINING THAT "mutual trust is the most important strategic asset today" and that the world "suffers from a shortage of trust", Prime Minister Narendra Modi Tuesday told leaders of the G7, including US President Donald Trump, that the "future of our partnerships depends on rebuilding this trust".

Welcoming efforts to end the crisis in West Asia, Modi, while addressing the leaders at the summit in Evian-les-Bains in eastern France, flagged the issue of the Strait of Hormuz and the



PM Narendra Modi with President Donald Trump in Evian, Tuesday. AP

death of Indians, including seafarers, in the conflict.

"We welcome the progress

made in peace efforts in West Asia. Our friendly nations in

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

India seeks \$900-mn steel quota to end UK trade deal logjam

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 16

INDIA IS pushing for a steel quota in the UK market worth nearly \$900 million under the bilateral free trade agreement (FTA) signed in July 2025 in a bid to resolve the ongoing row over steel curbs announced by the UK, *The Indian Express* has learned.

This has delayed implementation of the trade deal even though negotiations were concluded a year ago.

The move comes after the Indian steel industry flagged that the quotas announced by the UK would end up limiting even the current levels of Indian steel and products exports despite the FTA, and asked the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 17~06~2026

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Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.



[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Telegram

anything and the leaks “simply moved to other apps”, Durov said.

The Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY) carried out the action under Section 69A of the IT Act at the behest of the National Testing Agency. It also directed the company to disable, in India, its message-editing feature in respect of messages already posted on the platform until June 30, to address “the specific structural feature through which the platform has been used to fabricate after-the-event ‘paper leak’ evidence in respect of national examinations”.

The Telegram app can, however, be used through a connection over a virtual private network (VPN).

A senior government official said that in conversations with Telegram representatives in India, it was conveyed that the company should support ongoing probes into the paper leak, and subsequent claims, by providing metadata and other logs related to messages sent on the platform. Logs are information about messages and who sent them, and can include details like timestamp of a message, IP address, phone number, and device details, among others.

On why action was necessitated against only Telegram, NTA Director General Abhishek Singh told *The Indian Express* the platform was not taking any “proactive action” to deal with channels claiming to provide access to the question paper. “We were playing cat-and-mouse,” he said about NTA’s efforts to report channels claiming to have access to the NEET-UG question paper.

“They (the Telegram officials) told us that Telegram does not store logs and other related information related to messages, so they were unable to share any information with us. We also conveyed to their local representatives to involve their higher-ups abroad in the discussions, but they were non-responsive,” another official said on condition of anonymity.

According to Telegram’s privacy policy, if the company receives a “valid order,” from relevant judicial authorities confirming that a particular user is a suspect in a case involving criminal activities that violate the platform’s terms of service, it will “perform a legal analysis of the request and may disclose (the user’s) IP address and phone number to the relevant authorities”.

However, Telegram also offers a service called ‘secret chats,’ which are essentially end-to-end-encrypted conversa-

tions, and the company does not keep any logs for messages sent under the feature, and as a result does not know “who or when you messaged via secret chats,” its privacy policy states. Such messages, according to the company, can only be accessed from the device they were sent to or from. Queries sent to the IT Ministry and Telegram did not elicit a response until publication.

A second government official said the government had to resort to collating channels and accounts that investigative agencies believed were involved in either the initial leak, or were making subsequent claims about having access to the re-exam paper, and were issuing takedown orders. “But that became an overwhelming task as such channels and accounts kept resurfacing,” this official said.

There is acknowledgement within a section of the government that blocking an entire application may not prove to be a popular decision, and allegations of overreach could be made, especially given that the Centre, on a number of occasions in the past, has been criticised for its overtly sensitive stance on blocking of online content.

In a statement, the NTA said over the last few weeks, Telegram channels operating openly on the platform demanded sums ranging from a few thou-

sand to several lakhs of rupees from candidates and their families, in exchange for purported access to the re-examination paper. As per the NTA, some of these channels were openly advertising their purpose through their names: “PAPER LEAKED NEET”, “Re-NEET 2026”, “Private Mafia”, and “REE NEET MAFIAA”. It clarified that no such papers were available “outside the secured examination chain,” it added.

According to the NTA, the message-editing feature on Telegram, in its present form, permits a channel administrator to edit the content of a previously posted message – including the substitution of attached files such as PDFs – while the original send-time stamp is retained. “This capability has been used, in respect of multiple recent examinations, to fabricate after-the-event ‘paper leak’ artefacts: a channel administrator edits an older, innocuous message to insert the actual question paper after the examination has been conducted, and the resulting chat is then circulated as purported ‘evidence’ that the paper was in circulation before the examination. The MeitY direction closes this avenue of fabrication for the post-examination window in which such artefacts have historically been deployed,” the NTA said.

Steel quota

government to at least ensure a quota equivalent to the three-year average of India’s steel and steel products exports to the UK.

Government officials have said that India will move to curb Scotch whisky as a retaliatory measure if Indian interests are hurt. “Our quota needs to be at least the average of the last three years’ exports. The quota announced by the UK, which is set to come into effect from July 1, is far below that level, and the steel industry will end up suffering despite the FTA. The industry would end up taking a large hit in at least 6 categories where we have a significant export interest. Our exports are far higher

E. EXPLAINED

UK’s safeguards

UK’s steel safeguards will be effective July 1. Plus its Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) will kick in on January 1, 2027. The UK government has said sectoral and product-level scope of the CBAM will be kept under review beyond 2027.

than their proposed quota,” a source told *The Indian Express*.

Industrial exports to the UK are facing two major regulatory impediments, even after concluding the trade negotiations. Officials said the immediate worry is the steel quota because

it comes into effect on July 1. It will be followed by the UK’s Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) set to come into effect on January 1, 2027.

A query emailed to the Ministry did not elicit a response.

Under the CBAM regulation, the UK will place a carbon price on some of the most emissions-intensive industrial goods imported to the UK – covering the aluminium, cement, fertiliser, hydrogen, and iron & steel sectors – which are considered at risk of carbon leakage. But the scope will increase going forward.

“The sectoral and product-level scope of the CBAM will be kept under review beyond 2027 as new evidence comes to light to reflect changes to carbon leakage risk, as well as methodologi-

cal and technological advances,” a UK government statement read.

India’s exports of iron and steel and their products to the UK stood at \$893.4 million in 2025-26, accounting for a significant share of \$13.4 billion in total merchandise exports to the UK.

Maintaining that overcapacity was hurting the country’s steel manufacturing industry, the UK in March lowered the tariff-free quota on imported steel and doubled the tariff on imports exceeding that quota from 25% to 50%. Trade experts said such measures are typically announced to curb trade diversion from other countries, particularly the EU and the US. Both the EU and the US have also raised tariffs on steel outside quotas to 50%.

Modi at G7

the region have suffered loss of life and property due to this conflict. Disruptions to maritime trade in the Strait of Hormuz have harmed the global economy. Many Indian civilians have lost their lives. It is our responsibility to ensure the safety of the seafarers who connect nations through global maritime trade. We must ensure that maritime routes remain secure and that seafarers can perform their duties without fear,” he said.

At least 13 Indians, including three seafarers, have died in separate incidents over the last three and half months. Ships with Indian seafarers have come under attacks — three Indians died in one such attack by the US Navy near Oman — and Delhi lodged an official protest with the Trump administration after summoning the US charge d’affaires twice and during a phone call between External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and US Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

“International partnerships and global solidarity become meaningful only when we address shared challenges together. India firmly believes that lasting solutions to the tensions and conflicts unfolding in various parts of the world can only be achieved through dialogue, diplomacy, and international cooperation,” Modi said. He made these remarks at the summit where he met Trump, their first face-to-face encounter since their meeting at the White House in February 2025.

Modi and Trump will be meeting for a structured bilateral meeting Wednesday on the summit sidelines. India and US have been trying to repair ties that were severely strained in 2025 after Trump’s claims of mediation between India and Pakistan post Operation Sindoor and Washington’s decision to impose heavy tariffs on Delhi. The two countries are currently firming up a bilateral trade deal.

The G7 meeting is taking

place at a time when the US and Iran have agreed on a deal to end the war in West Asia.

Modi, who addressed the Outreach Session on ‘Forging New Partnerships and Rebuilding International Solidarity’, said, “Today’s world is more interconnected and interdependent than ever before. A nation’s energy security, food security, health security, cyber security, and economic prosperity are not determined solely within its own borders. Mobility, data, capital, and technology — all these elements bind us together.”

“In such times, the importance of partnerships naturally grows. However, partnerships succeed only when trust lies at their core. Today, the most crucial strategic asset is not a mineral, technology, or market, but mutual trust.”

“Trust that technology and supply chains will be used for the global good rather than as weapons. Trust that development opportunities will not be confined to a select few nations. Trust that global institutions will be capable of fulfilling the aspirations of all countries.”

“In the last century, humanity endured two world wars. After immense sacrifice, the global community developed systems to move towards peace, stability, and prosperity. Trust was the foundation of these systems. Yet, the trust built over decades and through the contributions of many generations is being undermined today. Covid held up a mirror to us, revealing just how hollow the claims of trust and solidarity truly were,” he said.

“Today the world does not suffer from a shortage of resources; it suffers from a shortage of trust. And the future of our partnerships depends on building this trust,” he said.

“US President Ronald Reagan famously said: ‘Trust, but verify.’ This remains relevant even today. We have a responsibility towards future generations to build a trusted, rules-based order suited to this new era,” he said.



SC seeks Govt reply on plea against Aadhaar use as citizenship proof

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 16

THE SUPREME Court on Tuesday issued notice on a plea against alleged use of Aadhaar as proof of citizenship and age despite laws to the contrary.

A bench of CJI Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana sought the response of the Centre, states, UTs, Election Commission and UIDAI on a PIL filed by Advocate Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay.

The plea pointed out that Section 9 of the Aadhaar Act 2016, expressly states that Aadhaar is “not the evidence of citizenship or domicile” and a UIDAI notification dated 22.08.2023 clearly states that Aadhaar “is proof of identity, not of citizenship, address or date of birth”. The apex court and various High Courts too have held that Aadhaar is not the proof of age, he pointed out.

“Despite this, the Aadhaar is not only being used as a proof of age, citizenship; domicile for school admission, property purchase and to obtain birth certificate, ration card, driving licence but also being used in Application Form for New Voter Registration (Form-6) as

a proof of date of birth, proof of residence,” the PIL said. Consequently, “infiltrators; illegal immigrants are obtaining various documents using the Aadhaar,” it said.

Upadhyay pointed out that “currently, as per Form-6 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, Aadhaar can be submitted as proof of date of birth and residence, which runs contrary to the UIDAI Office Memorandum and the judgments passed by this Hon’ble Court and various High Courts”.

He said this raises the legal question whether Form-6 has become temporally unreasonable for failing to keep up with the legislative intent and whether enrollment system under Form-6 is arbitrary for failing to provide a robust system of verification and distinction between lawfully entered foreign nationals and infiltrators.

Highlighting the ill-effects of illegal immigration on the polity, the PIL said “infiltration is a weapon of political parties to subvert electoral process for their benefit. Bengal, Assam and other Northeastern states have been afflicted by cheap political tactics”.

At G7 meet, Carney invites Modi to visit Canada; both vow to strengthen relations

Urges stronger cooperation in defence, energy supplies, security

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 16

A YEAR after they began the reset of ties at the G7 Summit in Canada, Prime Minister Narendra Modi met Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney on the sidelines of the G7 Summit in Evian, France, on Tuesday. They agreed to strengthen co-operation in defence, information security and energy.

Carney also invited Modi to visit Canada by the end of the year, as the two sides are working on signing the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA).

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said in a joint statement, “The two Prime Ministers welcomed the positive momentum in India-Canada relations and noted with satisfaction the progress achieved since Prime Minister Carney’s successful visit to India in March 2026.”



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, US President Donald Trump, French President Emmanuel Macron and other world leaders during the G7 summit in Evian-les-Bains, France, on Tuesday. PTI

Reaffirming their commitment to building a forward-looking strategic partnership, it said that the leaders underscored the complementarities between the Indian and Canadian economies and highlighted the importance of “resilient and reliable supply chains in strengthening global energy and food security”.

On energy supply, the MEA said that the leaders reviewed progress in bilateral economic cooperation, including devel-

opments in “commercial arrangements relating to LNG, LPG and metallurgical coal”.

On the bilateral trade pact, it said that the leaders welcomed the ongoing momentum in the exchange of high-level visits between the two countries. They took note of the recent visit by the Minister of Commerce and Industry, Piyush Goyal, to Canada and looked forward to the forthcoming Canadian trade mission to India later in 2026.

“Both sides expressed satisfaction with the progress in negotiations towards a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement and reaffirmed their shared objective of concluding the negotiations in 2026,” it said.

On defence and security ties, it said, “To further deepen defence and security cooperation, the Prime Ministers agreed to launch negotiations on a General Security of Information Agreement (GSOIA).

They also welcomed recent exchanges between defence institutions, including the visit of the National Defence College of India to Canada.”

It said that the two leaders welcomed the strengthening of institutional engagement between the two governments, including the recent meetings of the Joint Science and Technology Committee and the Consular Dialogue. They also looked forward to forthcoming dialogues in the areas of defence,

finance and migration. They noted ongoing collaboration under the Canada-India Talent and Innovation Strategy, including initiatives to strengthen skill development, innovation partnerships, and educational cooperation between institutions in the two nations.

Modi expressed India’s support for Canada becoming a Dialogue Partner of the Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA), it said. They announced the establishment of Raisina Americas as a platform to further strengthen dialogue, exchanges and cooperation.

“Prime Minister Modi thanked Prime Minister Carney for his invitation to visit Canada in 2026. Both sides agreed to remain engaged through diplomatic channels to work towards a mutually convenient date for the visit,” it said.

This is a major turnaround in ties after two years of hostility between the two countries when former PM of Canada Justin Trudeau had alleged Indian government’s “potential” involvement in the killing of pro-Khalistan separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar. India has rejected the charges, calling them “politically motivated” and “absurd”.



● POLICY

‘Like real life, kids need rules for social media use’



EXPERT EXPLAINS

Ravi Iyer

MANAGING DIRECTOR, UNIVERSITY OF SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA'S MARSHALL NEELY CENTER

SIX MONTHS after Australia banned social media for those under 16, the UK became the latest country to tighten online safety for children. UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer has announced that under-16s would be banned from social media by spring 2027. **Uma Vishnu** spoke to **Ravi Iyer**, a social psychologist who has earlier worked at Meta (then Facebook), where he led data science, research and product teams. He collaborated closely with Jonathan Haidt to develop the government policy and collective action sections of the latter's *The Anxious Generation* (2024).

What is the best approach: a blanket ban, tobacco-style warning labels or design changes on platforms?

I often refer to it as an age limit, not a ban. In Australia, for example, if you want to use YouTube, you still can; just that you can't create an account (if you are under 16). And if you can't create an account, you won't get notifications late at night, you won't get as personalised an experience, you won't get messages from strangers, you can't post your own images and see how people react. You can still access the content. If there's an educational video you want to watch, you can still watch it. You can also send it to your friends. So children are not being prevented from reading or watching whatever they want. It's a limit on the contractual relationship you had formed with a company that targeted you in ways that may be inappropriate. The warning-label idea is difficult because you are relying on teenagers, who don't always have a lot of self-control, to heed the warning. I do think design changes have a lot of promise. Take privacy settings. When you join a service, should you automatically be recommended to other people as a friend? In India, you have locked profiles, which give people a way to be safer and more private. Maybe that should be the de-

● PATCHWORK OF STATE PROPOSALS, CENTRE WEIGHS ACTION

CENTRE

- The Indian Express reported this March that the government was not in favour of an outright ban, and was instead considering a more nuanced and graded approach in specifying restrictions for children under 18 years.
- Government sources said that there will be distinct sets of restrictions for those in the 8-12 years age bracket, for 12 to 16-year-olds, and for those aged 16-18 years.

ANDHRA PRADESH

- Chief Minister N Chandrababu said in March 2026 that his government would roll out a programme to prevent children under 13 from accessing social media within 90 days.
- The state, Naidu said, was also considering regulating access to social media for those in the 13-16 age group.

KARNATAKA

- In March 2026, Karnataka announced a proposal to ban social media use for children under 16 in its 2026-27 Budget, becoming the first Indian state to do so.



- A separate draft policy for 'Responsible Digital Use Among Students' includes suggestions such as capping screen time to one hour, cutting off internet access after 7 pm and implementing Aadhaar-enabled sign-ups.

GOA

- Goa is also weighing a social media ban for children under the age of 16, according to reports in January 2026.

fault for children everywhere, rather than something they have to turn on themselves.

Design changes are great, but I also think we should have age limits for children because companies have not made these changes on their own. They have historically done whatever is possible to get as many people, including children, to use these products as much as possible.

How is Australia's policy working?

One survey noted that 70% of children in Australia are still on social media, but that means that 30% are now off. Many of them are using these platforms without an account. Platforms like Snapchat, where accounts are more essential, have dropped usage more than platforms like YouTube, where the experience of viewing content is largely the same without an account.

We may not get today's 15-year-olds off these platforms, but norms are changing such that children who are 12 today will feel less pressure to be on these platforms when they are 15. We have speed limits that people don't always obey, but they still serve a purpose. We have drinking ages that some teenagers circumvent, but they still serve a purpose. In the offline world, my children can't simply pretend to be 25. They're consistently treated as children. Digital services should work the same way.

Parents often have this guilt that they

How they keep you hooked

Ephemeral content that says 'if you don't see this now, it will go away'.

- AI-powered systems that predict the notification that will get you to come back.

- Infinite scroll and autoplay that reduce your ability to exercise your willpower.

aren't doing enough to keep their kids off the phone.

Everyone has a role to play in this. A lot of what companies do is rely on 'network effects'. No child wants to be the one who is not on Snapchat if all the other children are on Snapchat. And no parent wants to be the one who stops their child from being on these products when every other kid is on it. So there is a real collective action problem. We need to make parents' jobs a lot easier.

Many tech companies would say high engagement simply means users are finding value in their products.

If that were true, companies would not have to use every trick in the book to increase the usage of their products. You can ask any group of adults or kids if they want to be using their phone as much as they are. Most people will say they want to use their phones less. Kids are still developing self-control. I don't let my kids order whenever they want to from a restaurant for a reason. Similarly, we shouldn't expect kids to have the same self-control online and we shouldn't let companies target them in the same way.

What is it about social media design that makes these platforms addictive?

The companies are making these things more tempting, more powerful, more novel through algorithms that are constantly trying to figure out what they can show you.

● TECH

Telegram ban: Why the app is under scanner for paper leaks

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, June 16

THE MINISTRY of Electronics and IT has blocked the popular messaging platform Telegram in India until June 22 at the request of the National Testing Agency (NTA), responsible for conducting the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET).

It follows the cancellation and rescheduling of the undergraduate medical entrance exam earlier this year due to widespread allegations of paper leaks and irregularities. The platform is believed to have been used to circulate leaked questions and communicate with students, middlemen and others. The NEET is now scheduled for June 21.

Law behind block

The blocking order has been issued under Section 69(A) of the Information Technology Act, 2000. It empowers the government to issue directions for blocking public access to digital information.

For such orders to be issued, the Central government must be satisfied that it is necessary or expedient to do so, "in the interest of sovereignty and integrity of India, defence of India, security of the State, friendly relations with foreign States or public order or for preventing incitement to the commission of any cognizable offence relating to above..." It may, for reasons to be recorded in writing, direct any agency "to intercept, monitor or decrypt or cause to be intercepted or monitored or decrypted any information generated, transmitted, received or stored in any computer resource."

APP'S ORIGINS

- Pavel Durov founded Telegram along with his elder brother, Nikolai, in 2013, positioning it as focused on privacy.
- It allowed large groups and synced with multiple devices — its edge over WhatsApp.

Telegram's USP

Pavel Durov founded Telegram along with his elder brother, Nikolai, in 2013, positioning the app as being particularly focused on user privacy. It allowed large groups with up to 2,00,000 members, and synced with multiple devices — features that gave it an edge over the likes of WhatsApp. In 2025, Russian-origin Durov said the app had over a billion active users worldwide. Telegram is among the most popular personal messaging apps in India with over 150 million users, behind only Meta's WhatsApp. The high degree of privacy has also led to scams, the dissemination of child pornography and other illegal activities. In 2024, France arrested Durov over moderation concerns. Telegram rejected the claims, saying: "We have to process legitimate requests to take down illegal public content (e.g., sticker sets, bots, and channels) within the app."

However, it has linked restrictions to freedom of speech, stating that "this does not apply to local restrictions on freedom of speech," clarifying that "if criticizing the government is illegal in some country, Telegram won't be a part of such politically motivated censorship". The Indian government has also issued a direction to Telegram to disable its message-editing feature for messages already posted until June 30. According to the NTA, the feature permits a channel administrator to edit the content of a previously posted message — including the substitution of attached files such as PDFs — while the original send-time stamp is retained.

Rationale behind ban

In a statement, the NTA said that over the last few weeks, Telegram channels operating openly on the platform demanded sums ranging from a few thousand to several lakhs of rupees from candidates in exchange for purported access to the re-examination paper. Durov posted on X that the order "punishes 150M+ ordinary Telegram users in India — not the insiders who leaked the exam materials. And the ban hasn't stopped anything. The leaks just moved to other apps."

On Monday, Ahmedabad police arrested two Rajasthan men for allegedly running a racket that defrauded medical aspirants and their parents via Telegram by claiming to have the NEET (UG) re-examination question paper and offering to sell it. Police said the duo did not possess any leaked documents.

● HEALTH

You always needed cough syrup prescription: What's changed & why

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, June 16

THE UNION government has removed cough syrups from the list of medicines that receive certain exemptions in manufacturing and sale, such as availability in general stores in smaller villages. This comes after a spate of recent incidents where children have died after consuming contaminated syrups.

The Union Health Ministry, in a gazette notification, removed the word "syrup" from Schedule K of the Drug Rules.

Does this mean you need a prescription?

Even before this notification, a doctor's prescription was required for almost all cough syrup formulations. The removal from Schedule K removes just one exemption that allowed general stores in smaller villages with a population of less than 1,000 to sell these syrups.

In other areas, cough syrups can only be sold at licensed medical stores with a pharmacist on site.

Why was the step taken?

It comes after several incidents of children dying because of contaminants in cough syrups. The oversight measure was first discussed in a meeting of the apex drug regulator's Drug Consultative Committee (DCC) last November, after the deaths of at least 22 children in Madhya Pradesh's Chhindwara.

The step, however, has been described as "too little, too late" by experts in drug regulation. "This exemption was meant only for cough syrups that do not contain any Schedule H or X drugs (which are to be sold on the prescription of a Registered Medical Practitioner only). But almost all cough syrups contain at least one component that is regulated. This meant that they should not have been sold without a prescription anyway, but, in practice, they are widely available over the counter," said a former drug regulator, on condition of anonymity.

They added: "The only cough syrups that do not contain any of the regulated substances are herbal remedies, and they are not governed by these norms... despite

Speak to a doctor first

- Every cough needs to be treated differently and you do not need to take a cough syrup for most, says Dr Suranjit Chatterjee, senior consultant, Internal Medicine, Indraprastha Apollo hospital.
- People experiencing a dry, hacking cough can use a cough suppressant.

- However, no cough syrup should be used for a cough with phlegm, as it can dry out the phlegm in the lungs, says Dr Chatterjee.

some of them using propylene glycol (PEG), which is usually the source of the contaminant."

Contamination with diethylene glycol and ethylene glycol usually happens in syrups when non-pharmaceutical grade PEG is used as a solvent in its manufacturing, without appropriate testing.

How can regulation happen?

Experts say certain measures are likely to better prevent contamination.

One, as discussed in the meeting, is using solvents that carry a lower risk of contamination. Two, while PEG is needed as a solvent for syrups, companies can manufacture suspensions of the same drug (which contain insoluble particles) without using it. An industry expert said, "Syrups are just sweeter and better tasting, suspensions can be equally efficacious and stable."

Three, as the industry discussed with the drug regulator in the aftermath of the deaths in MP and other global cases linked to India-made syrups, was to ensure smaller packs of PEG are available.

The industry expert said, "PEG is

usually sold in big barrels, which is good for the big companies. But cough syrups are manufactured in very small units as well. They do not buy PEG by the barrel, they instead procure it from the open market. Their containers do not carry the company seal, and there is no way to track where the contamination enters in the supply chain." At times, suppliers could sell cheaper, industrial-grade PEG as pharmaceutical-grade.

What precautions should you take?

Experts advise that people should only buy cough syrups from established brands to reduce the chances of contamination.

Every cough needs to be treated differently, and patients do not need to take cough syrups for most of them. Dr Suranjit Chatterjee, senior consultant for internal medicine at Indraprastha Apollo Hospital in Delhi, says, "In most cases, people are likely to get better on their own without a cough syrup, and, in some cases, taking a cough syrup when the cough lasts for long can lead to misdiagnosis of the underlying condition."

● HISTORY

How a Mohenjo-daro figurine became a 'dancer' — and a challenge to 'modesty'

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, June 16

A CLASS 9 textbook shaded over the bare torso of the iconic "Dancing Girl" of Mohenjo-daro before the NCERT (National Council of Educational Research and Training) decided to restore its original image.

This was not the first time an attempt had been made to cover up the Harappan-era bronze figurine. In 2023, a fully clothed version of the "Dancing Girl" was unveiled as the mascot of the International Museum Expo.

The story of "vulgarity" being attached to the statue, however, dates back several decades. It is largely associated with archaeologist John Marshall choosing to interpret it as the image of a "nautch girl" or "dancing girl" without compelling evidence.

Competing claims

The government of Pakistan also had similar reservations when it was trying to acquire Harappan artefacts from India in the 1950s, arguing that Mohenjo-daro and

Harappa were both in Pakistan. India, however, contended that the legacy of the Harappan civilisation belonged to South Asia and not Pakistan alone.

An academic paper by Panjab University historian Ashish Kumar, *Sahib's Nautch Girl*, brings out interesting details. Around 12,000 Harappan objects from Mohenjo-daro were in Delhi when Partition took place. These had been brought to the capital from the Lahore Museum by Mortimer Wheeler, who was Director General of the Archeological Survey of India between 1944 and 1948, for an exhibition.

"Owing to partition, almost all of the Harappan sites including Mohenjodaro and Harappa went to Pakistan leaving with India only two minor sites (Rangpur in Gujarat and Kotla Nihang Khan in East Punjab) of the first urban civilization of the Indian subcontinent," Kumar writes. "Since the Harappan artifacts had been found in the territory of Pakistan at Mohenjodaro, the Pakistani officials demanded all these artifacts back from India. But the Indian officials refused to en-



The bronze figurine was discovered in 1926

ertain this demand and put forth an equal claim over the Harappan civilization."

Finally, India and Pakistan agreed to a

50:50 division of the Harappan artifacts "found at Mohenjodaro and Chanhudaro with the help of Mortimer Wheeler".

While Pakistan wanted both the 'Dancing Girl' and the 'Priest King', India was willing to hand over just one of the two.

"The Pakistani officials chose the priest king to avoid any backlash at home that a figure of a naked teenager could have invoked from religious quarters," Kumar writes. "Here the 'nudity' of a teenager girl impacted the decision of the Pakistani officials, who considered its sexuality as a threat to their moral beliefs."

However, the clamour to acquire the 'Dancing Girl' statue continued in Pakistan till recently too. In 2016, a writ petition in the Lahore High Court sought directions to the Pakistani government "to bring back the famous 'Dancing girl' bronze statue from India", Kumar states.

"Since this bronze girl statue had been discovered from Mohenjo-daro in 1926, Pakistan was held to be the real owner of this five thousand years old Harappan artifact," the

paper says. "In response to this Pakistani claim, Vasant Shinde (then Vice-chancellor of Deccan College, Pune) questioned Pakistan's exclusive claim over the Harappan civilization... since this civilization was considered a common heritage of South Asia."

'Nautch girl'

Significantly, even the identification of the statue as that of a dancing girl by John Marshall is contested. Marshall wrote about the statue: "The only other sculpture in the round from Mohenjo-daro that claims notice here is the bronze dancing-girl... This is a small figurine of rather rough workmanship with disproportionately long arms and legs. Almost, indeed, it is a caricature, but, like a good caricature, it gives a vivid impression of the young aboriginal nautch girl, her hand on hip in half-impudent posture, and legs slightly forward, as she beats time to the music with her feet."

He added: "Small, too, as this figurine is, the modeling of the back, hips, and buttocks is quite effective, and in spite of ob-

vious defects shows sound observation on the part of the artist."

However, Gregory L Possehl, in his book *The Indus Civilisation*, expressed doubt whether the statue represents a female dancer. Historian Upinder Singh also said in *A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India*: "The dancing girl may not have been dancing at all, and even if she was, she may not represent a professional dancer."

Ashish Kumar also says that there is no evidence to suggest that she was a dancer. The fact that colonial officials, who stayed in India alone, would often find comfort in the company of nautch girls, may have led to the instant association, he says. Marshall also associated the bronze statue with the devdasi tradition, thus suggesting continuity from Harappan times to recent times.

Significantly, while many nude terracotta representations of the female body were found from Harappan sites, these were identified as a marker of the Mother Goddess cult, while the bronze statue was identified as a "nautch girl".

The Editorial Page

WEDNESDAY, JUNE 17, 2026

On US-Iran ceasefire, the mediation question is the wrong one

Indian cities need to rethink water future

THE HEAT wave in several parts of the country has been aggravated by severe water shortage, driven by a groundwater crisis and falling reservoir levels. The emergency has shone a light on the challenges faced by cities, including metros such as Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, and Chennai. The conventional explanation points to weather vagaries. Rising temperatures increase evaporation losses. However, climate change alone cannot explain why large parts of the country are parched. NITI Aayog's Composite Water Management Index (CWMI) had warned of a dire situation in 2018. While the timelines estimated in the report may not have been accurate, the CWMI's warning — Indian cities are living beyond their hydrological means — should have prompted a course correction. Since then, several other studies, including the Jal Shakti Ministry's latest Dynamic Groundwater Resources Assessment, have flagged the oversaturation of aquifers. The problem, however, is that municipal and state-level authorities treat every crisis as an isolated event and very little has been done to address the structural reasons for water shortfall during the dry season.

Urban India's inefficiency in water use stems from dilapidated distribution networks, inadequate metering, and poor municipal governance. Not treating wastewater and underharvesting of rainwater prevent the optimum use of scarce resources. In 2016, the Mihir Shah Committee had pointed out that "the focus of water policy in independent India had been on augmenting supplies with little attention being paid to the demand-side management of water". This policy direction did play a major role in meeting food-security imperatives, but as the Shah Committee pointed out, there has been little emphasis on institutional innovations in the water sector. Since then, programmes such as the Atal Bhujal Yojana have taken early steps to encourage efficient use of water in agriculture. However, demand-side management also requires scientific analyses of water use at the household and industrial level, especially to prevent overexploitation by the well-heeled.

In recent years, a few cities have begun to supplement grey infrastructure — drains and pipes — with nature-based solutions. Lake restoration projects, such as those in Mumbai and Bengaluru, are welcome endeavours. However, these need to be taken up at scale to have a meaningful impact. The country still lacks a concerted policy like China's Sponge City project that uses urban landscapes and green infrastructure, such as permeable pavements, to promote natural retention of rainwater. The recent crisis should occasion conversations on such methods — cities that get flooded during monsoons shouldn't be parched in summers.

IT IS not clear how the Iran-US deal will unfold over the next several months. The announced ceasefire and framework are more of a mechanism to postpone resolving deeper divides that still pose risks. Even if it survives, the deal will be at best a sullen ceasefire, not a peace settlement. Ahead of elections, the Donald Trump administration has incentives to avoid appearing bogged down as well as to avoid the risk of inflation and energy shocks. Once that constraint is removed, will Trump accept the strategic reality of the limits of American power? Or will he, and the American system, succumb to temptation to satiate wounded pride?

Israel, so far, has had every motive to undermine a possible agreement. Israel's quest for complete military dominance has not produced either security or lasting control. It is diplomatically isolated. But the war may produce other convulsions in the region: States like Iraq become more likely sites of proxy competition. Iran's effective practice of sovereignty has hugely exposed the vulnerabilities and costs to the Gulf states of letting the US set the terms for the region. But all these states, Iran included, could still see domestic political turmoil that complicates any peace calculus.

In India, there is much hand-wringing over the fact that it was an irrelevant player in this entire conflict. But India's diagnosis of this irrelevance, and what the world needs now, is deeply mistaken. Any mature power should not worry about who gets to mediate. India did not have the leverage, al-

liance relationships, or, frankly, the diplomatic ability to mediate. India and the world should welcome any mediation that achieves a lasting peace. So, credit to Pakistan, Qatar, Oman, whoever gets the world to where it needs to be. Even on India and Pakistan, we have misplaced pride. The sensible response is not to deny mediation, but to judge the mediator by results: If Pakistan moves toward genuine peace, on terms that are acceptable to us, the mediator should be welcomed. This is a tall order. But the formal obsession with denying "mediation" has cost us. In a nutshell, the problem with India's diagnosis of its irrelevance is that it is asking the wrong question.

We need to understand a basic fact about the current global situation. We have been consistently framing every war — Ukraine, Gaza, Iran — as if these were bilateral or limited regional affairs. There is a sense in which, of course, they are not our wars. But collectively, these wars have brought the world to unprecedented risks. None of these are regional conflicts. All of them increase the likelihood of catastrophic global economic or military risk. All of them, in their own way, represent the most massive rolling back of norms that underpin any viable international order, restraints on the use of force, respect for sovereignty, and minimal credibility for international law.

In the case of Israel's war on Gaza, the world comes close to seeing genocide in the 21st cen-



PRATAP BHANU MEHTA

Now that there is a ceasefire, the task for global diplomacy is not just to ensure that the ceasefire holds. It is to ask whether a measure of international order and norms can be restored

tury. But other things are moving the world to greater catastrophic risks: Drones have become an extraordinary technology for self-defence. But unregulated, they might proliferate violence more effectively than states can control them. We have already seen effects in Sudan and Yemen, as they have been used by states that are our closest friends. The Iran war has normalised another precedent: The legitimisation of political assassination as an instrument of statecraft. Even if the ceasefire holds in Iran, we are lowering the barriers against systematic global violence.

Where does India come into this? First of all, we spoke with forked tongues about our own positions. We were not, as they say, multi-aligned as we claimed to be. Iran is a complicated power in its region, often disruptive for states in the region, but also a victim of unrequited US attention and an important pillar of any conceivable regional balance. We politically embraced Israel with unrequited enthusiasm, the US, and later the UAE, and in doing so, put ourselves squarely on the side of political forces that were carpet bombing, literally, the international order. The problem was not these relationships; India has stakes in them. But the sense of being a supplicant in the face of the US, and too cowardly to name any crime in the international order, is palpably visible for the world to see. The problem is that we are seen as incapable of de-

fending any principle whatsoever.

Of course, most powers, especially in the West, are deeply hypocritical. But a mature power does not use others' hypocrisy to condone the kind of international nihilism India has condoned, trying to disguise it behind platitudes about world peace. Now that there is a ceasefire, the task for global diplomacy is not just to ensure that the ceasefire holds. It is to ask whether a measure of international order and norms can be restored. We are in a context where one major power, like the US, is trying to be a revisionist power. The rest of the world has been under the illusion that the way to respond to this is to construct bilateral deals. But the task of mobilising global coalitions that can speak for norms and minimise the possibility of catastrophic risks is a wide open one. India's only diplomatic relevance can be to bat for those norms.

The world needs to use this ceasefire to reassemble support for principles and public goods that make international order possible. The important thing is that this is also in India's long-term self-interest and the only source of its leverage. What India lost in the last couple of years was not its power to mediate; it was the sense that no one had any idea what India stood for. There is much consternation against the moralising of pre-2014 foreign policy. It had its limitations. But now it has been replaced by vacuity, masquerading as realism.

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express



The Ideas Page

WEDNESDAY, JUNE 17, 2026

India's challenge lies in navigating not between West and Rest, but within West



RAJA MANDALA

BY C RAJA MOHAN

NARENDRA MODI'S participation in the G7 summit at Évian this week marks India's 13th appearance at the forum and the Prime Minister's seventh in a row since 2019. Fittingly, India's engagement with the grouping began at Évian itself, when Atal Bihari Vajpayee was invited in 2003, and continued with Manmohan Singh between 2005 and 2009.

That India is a regular invitee reflects a deepening mutual engagement, rooted in the country's economic transformation since the 1990s and its growing salience in the international system. During the Cold War, India placed most of its economic and political eggs in the Russian basket. The Soviet collapse of 1991, coinciding with the breakdown of India's own economic model, forced a restructuring that profoundly altered Delhi's relationship with the West.

Today, the G7 is the principal destination of Indian exports, absorbing nearly a third of the country's merchandise shipments. Most of India's service exports also go to the G7. It is also the main destination for the outward flow of Indian professionals and students; a more restrictive America since Donald Trump's re-election as president has merely redirected some of those flows to Europe.

Despite the rhetoric about building a new global economic order with Russia and China, India's economic diplomacy in recent years has been less about BRICS than about deepening ties with the developed West through trade liberalisation. India's quest for diversification is now less between the West and BRICS than within the West — it is marked by a new determination to deepen ties with Europe, the UK and Canada in the G7.

India's real challenge today comes from



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

rapid and unexpected change within the West itself. Three trends stand out. The first is the rise of American unilateralism under Trump. Trump's instinct is to pursue the narrow national interest of the US in the name of "America First". As he forces allies to fall in line on key issues, the divisions across the Atlantic have widened.

Contrary to the popular notion of American decline, the US has grown stronger relative to its Western allies over three decades. In the mid-1990s, the European economy was roughly equal in size to America's, and Japan's GDP stood at two-thirds to three-quarters of it. Today, the eurozone is little more than half of US output and Japan barely a seventh. With its GDP at around \$31 trillion and still growing at 2.5 per cent, the US is set to widen its lead over allies and over China — the one power whose relative weight has risen, though Beijing's own troubles have dimmed the prospect of overtaking America.

Where many in Delhi's foreign policy community see an irreconcilable contradiction between the pursuit of strategic autonomy and partnership with the West, China demonstrated the art of transcending it — and against far steeper odds

To be sure, Washington has ceded some ground to Beijing in select frontier areas — advanced manufacturing, electric vehicles, increasingly competitive open-weight AI models. Trump's industrial policy is eager to make amends. But the depth of the American innovation system and its capital markets remains without parallel.

SpaceX's listing on the Nasdaq last week, on extravagant promises of a new space economy, pushed its paper valuation to \$2 trillion despite the absence of past profitability. What it really signals is a new technological revolution — in what China's communists call the "new quality productive forces". French President Emmanuel Macron's decision to seat the tech titans at Évian as near-equals underlines the rise of a new American tech capitalism with far-reaching consequences.

Third, Trump is recasting not only the internal balance of the West but the terms of its engagement with Russia and China. In

pursuit of a grand bargain with Tehran, he has strained the alliance with Israel; in South Asia, he is talking up Pakistan. His fluid new approaches, with no attachment to the past, promise to transform the geopolitics of Europe, the Middle East and the Indo-Pacific.

The task of Indian diplomacy is to manage these changes with patience and calm. The answers are only partly external; most lie at home — in restructuring the economy, modernising the defence industrial base, revitalising the technological ecosystem. Curiously, partnership with the West remains crucial to that effort.

That brings us back to Évian in 2003, where China's president, Hu Jintao, sat alongside Vajpayee — the first time Beijing was drawn into the Western outreach. China's GDP then was about \$1.6 trillion, India's barely \$600 billion. China has since raced to some \$20 trillion in 2025; India still hovers below \$4 trillion. The speed and purpose of internal transformation is what distinguishes China from India. It is not just a question of quantity. The quality of the Chinese economy in terms of its technological advances and scientific sophistication is more than impressive.

China's leaders are no longer invited to the G7, yet they loom large over it: A central question at Évian is how to manage the global imbalances produced by China's export juggernaut. That transformation underlines the twin dialectic China navigated with such aplomb over the last five decades: To rise through deeper ties with the West but also strengthen China's national capability. China today is at once a huge economic partner for the West and its principal strategic challenger.

Where many in Delhi's foreign policy community see an irreconcilable contradiction between the pursuit of strategic autonomy and partnership with the West, China demonstrated the art of transcending it — and against far steeper odds.

The writer is a contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express



AREFA TEHSIN

How (not) to save the Aravalli range

THE ARAVALLI is old. Older than the Himalaya, older than our arguments, older than our institutions and those who run them. It has survived glaciations, tectonic upheavals, and centuries of illegal mining. It did not, however, anticipate being improved.

Earlier this month, a leading Rajasthan newspaper ran a Sunday "positive" story about a plan by the forest department to plant saplings on rocky forest land through a technique called "double blasting". The hard, stony ground of the Aravallis — ground that has been hard and stony for approximately 1.5 billion years and is rather settled in its ways — will be blasted — twice — so that the earth becomes crumbly. And then a plant will be put in the resulting crater. The plant, presumably, will grow. Greenery will ensue. Rajasthan's 5,476 sq km of rocky forest will be transformed. The numbers will be issued. The paperwork will be filed with satisfaction.

My father, naturalist Raza H Tehsin, who spent a lifetime in these landscapes, finds this plan remarkable. Not because it is bad science (that it is) but because it so perfectly captures our relationship with nature: We love it so much that we must slash and overpower it first.

Double blasting is an engineering technique for breaking extremely hard rock — the kind that illegal miners have long cast long-

And yet, the basics remain this: If you fence a rocky patch, protect it from grazing, woodcutting and illegal mining, the vegetation belonging to that land will return by itself. It always does

ing looks at. You drill deep, you detonate in controlled stages, the rock fractures, the rubble crumbles. And then (here is the masterstroke) you plant something. The disturbed soil, we are told, will hold moisture longer. The roots will spread. Greenery will flourish where earlier there was only stubborn geological permanence.

That stubborn geological permanence is itself alive. Pradip Krishen writes in a recent article about the destruction of biocrusts — those thin, living skins of cyanobacteria, fungi, lichens and mosses that crust over rocky and arid soils. Science has only recently begun to grasp their importance: They fix nitrogen, stabilise soil, retain moisture, hold the whole fragile surface together. In Delhi, Krishen warns, the "restoration" of the Central Ridge is destroying these very crusts in the name of greening. Natural history writer Pranay Lal has written about how Delhi's Forest Department had specified a banned pesticide in its tender to "restore" the Central Ridge — not to heal it, but to theme-park it. There are 1-2 million ants and 7 million earthworms for every human on Earth. And this is not counting the biocrust. That is the kind of help we need to keep the Earth and soil going.

Rajasthan's Forest Department has, it seems, not read either piece.

Or, it has responded with a harrumph — it knows what it's doing. The blasting has been pitched as a pilot project covering about 5,000 sq km. If the pilot succeeds, if the saplings survive, if the numbers look good, if the press release lands well, there will be more blasting.

And yet, the basics remain this: If you fence a rocky patch, protect it from grazing, woodcutting and illegal mining, the vegetation belonging to that land will return by itself. It always does. The Aravalli, even in its most degraded patches, carries an ecological memory. Dhok, khair, ber, the tenacious grasses: They come back, given half a chance and a functioning fence. They don't need dynamite. They need us to stop. Blasting a landscape for its own benefit is something only we could think of. The Aravalli is 1.5 billion years old, and the secret of its longevity is not a formula our *dadi* told us about.

What happened to the time India took pride in worshipping nature? Those evening sessions of elders under a banyan tree, rolling the first roti for a bird, a deity associated with every hill and stream and forest? The culture that claimed nature as its god has discovered a new one — pilot projects with good PR. The saplings may or may not survive. The press release will.

Tehsin, former honorary wildlife warden, Udaipur, is the author, most recently, of The Great Indian Safari



The Big Picture

WEDNESDAY, JUNE 17, 2026

13

1 IN 5 SAILORS WORLDWIDE IS INDIAN

LIVES AT SEA

After months of hostilities in West Asia, the Strait of Hormuz is set to finally open. On many of the merchant ships that sail through the busy shipping lane will be Indians, among the world's biggest seafaring workforce. SUNANDA MEHTA on the dangers and thrills of the deep sea

THAT MORNING, Abdur Rahman Mondal thought he would be dead. Swallowed by the deep, dark waters of the Strait of Hormuz, his home in Mirjapur village, in Nadia district of West Bengal, more distant than ever. "All I could think of were the faces of my ageing parents, wife and sisters. I felt I would never be able to see them again," says the 27-year-old. An Able Seaman, Mondal was on board a Palau-flagged oil tanker that was hit by an Iran-fired missile while passing through the Strait of Hormuz on March 1.

Days later, Electro-Technical Officer Vineet Sharma, 28, crossed the same waters, his ship headed for India, fully loaded with oil from an Iranian port. "Luckily for us, it was a peaceful passage through the Strait, but the stress was immense. We had many briefings preparing us for that voyage. We were on constant alert, and could not relax for even a few minutes. Back home, our families waited for our call all day," says Sharma, who is from a village near Nainital, where his father is a postmaster.

With the Strait of Hormuz set to open after months of hostilities in West Asia as part of a long-awaited deal between Iran and the US, traffic will finally resume on one of the world's busiest shipping lanes. On board many of the ships that sail out will be Indians, among the largest contingent of sailors worldwide.

With 3.08 lakh sailors as of 2024, India ranks among the top three global suppliers of maritime personnel, alongside the Philippines and China, holding approximately 17% of global crew share. Today, nearly one in five seafarers worldwide is Indian.

During the recent war, 13 India-flagged vessels, with close to 550 Indian sailors aboard, were stuck in the Strait of Hormuz for more than 100 days. Across the broader Gulf region, more than 18,000 Indian seafarers were caught in the uncertainty.

For long, the Merchant Navy was seen as a well-paid, even glamorous, career. The loneliness, the psychological weight of being at sea for months, the isolation, these stayed aboard. So did the risks. Storms, accidents, piracy — and now, in the night waters of the Persian Gulf, the dread of a loitering munition dropping onto a loaded oil tanker and a full crew.

Yet, across India's cities and small towns, thousands continue to sign up for a career in the Merchant Navy.

Preparing for the sea

The Samundra Institute of Maritime Studies (SIMS) in Lonavala, one of India's premier maritime academies, sits in serenity, with sculpted lawns and enormous trees that canopy a glass-fronted main building. Walk far enough and the real purpose announces itself: a full-scale replica of a ship's aft, or the rear section, rises from the green — all steel and impressive.

This is the beating heart of the institute

that prepares 390 cadets for a world considerably more challenging than the brochure suggests.

The institute offers four programmes: a one-year DNS (Deck Navigation Science), a one-year GME (Graduate Marine Engineering), a BTech in Marine Engineering, and an ETO (Electro-Technical Officer) course. The postgraduate courses, particularly GME, which requires a mechanical engineering background, have seen a sharp drop in demand, but undergraduate programmes tell a very encouraging story, says SIMS Vice-Principal Captain Subhendu Hati.

"Two years ago, the unified IMU-CET entrance test conducted by the Indian Maritime University drew 39,000 applicants. Last year, there were 55,000 and this year, 72,000. Most of our cadets come from tier-2 cities, small towns and even rural areas," says Hati.

The Lonavala-Karjat belt is home to some of the country's best maritime institutes — besides SIMS, Anglo-Eastern, Great Eastern and Tolani. Most of these institutes are run by shipping companies that eventually employ the cadets on their ships. SIMS, for instance, is run by Executive Ship Management. "Our cadets have guaranteed placements on our own ships. In fact our intake usually depends on our requirements," says Hati.

On the SIMS campus, amid the rigorous daily routine of academics and practical training from 5.30 am to 10.30 pm, the dangers of war and the recent casualties have quietly crept into daily conversations.

"The war comes up constantly. Our faculty share their experiences, it becomes part of the preparation. But none of it has made us regret our decision," says Oren Pacheco, a 20-year-old cadet from Goa.

For Pacheco, the sea is an inheritance — his family on both sides worked on ships, mainly in the galley or kitchen. At 11, standing on a bridge at Marmagao Port in Goa, where his father's ship had docked for some days, he had decided he would do the same. Now studying for his Diploma in Nautical Sciences at SIMS, Pacheco discusses drone strikes and stranded tankers the way his father's generation discussed monsoons.

Jeeva Bharati, 23, from Chennai, graduates in two months. The first in his family to go to sea, he turned down desk jobs for a maritime career. Asked about sailing through active conflict zones, he says with pragmatism, "Tankers pay more... The war is a hurdle. We'll overcome it soon."

Of the 390 cadets at SIMS, 19 are women. They come here, raring to prove something beyond seamanship. Kheta Patel, 19, from Gujarat, says she was in Class 8, when she decided she wanted a life in uniform, a call that meant standing up to her parents. When she couldn't get into the National Defence Academy, she walked into the Merchant Navy. "Working with machines is challenging, but girls can do it too. It is possible."

This is what Kheta's teacher Captain



ARUL HORIZON



(Clockwise from above) Fourth Engineer Shubham Vaid on his vessel while crossing the Strait of Hormuz in May; cadets training in the engine room of a ship on the campus of Samundra Institute of Maritime Studies in Lonavala near Pune; cargo and commercial ships anchored in the Strait of Hormuz; of the 390 cadets at SIMS, 19 are women

Rajwinder Kaur, who retired as a Master, told herself when she joined the Shipping Corporation of India (SCI) in 2005.

Recalling her days aboard, she says she had to constantly prove her capability to her male counterparts, especially when it came to physical work like picking up the ropes, tying the ship or working long hours at the port. Dealing with isolation was tough, too. Before Internet connectivity reached ships, communication meant expensive satellite calls from the ship. Between those calls, her parents waited and worried, she says, adding that her male colleagues rarely carried that same emotional weight.

Ex-Chief Engineer Makrand Date, who teaches engineering subjects at SIMS, believes today's cadets are better prepared than his generation. "What I prepare them for is the mental and physical toughness this career demands," says Date, who survived a pirate attack during his sailing days. Merchant shipping, he adds, isn't usually a wartime target. "A merchant vessel operates like a Red Cross convoy — it carries no allegiance. That confidence is something I pass on to my cadets," he says.

Recalling his encounter with danger in 1999, Date says, "While serving as a Fourth Engineer, my ship experienced what the industry calls an 'armed robbery' — distinct from hijacking, but no less alarming. It happened in Brazil, while the vessel was at the port. The attackers — local seafarers, disguised and carrying guns and knives — boarded during a watch changeover around midnight, took money and valuables from the Captain and fled. Even now,

INDIAN SEAFARERS IN 2024

CREW
3,07,901

OFFICERS: 1,10,416 | NON-OFFICERS: 1,97,485

ENGINEERING: 1,00,792
NAUTICAL (NON-ENGINEERING): 2,07,109

CREW BY NAUTICAL WORK

Hospitality	12,818
Cook*	3,262
Salon*	9,447
Cruise	37,237
Deck Rating*	16,903
Wiper	3,578
Bosun	4,324
Able Seaman	16,568
Third Officer	40,303
Others	52,669

*Trainees included. Source: DG Shipping

more than two decades later, I remember the sequence of events that night."

Chirag Bahri calls his experience "life-changing". In April 2010, as a 28-year-old marine engineer, Bahri boarded the chemical tanker *MV Marida Marguerite*, bound for Belgium from Kandla, Gujarat. On May 8, 2010, as the ship crossed the Gulf of Aden, pirates boarded the vessel. Bahri, working in the engine room, was called to the bridge of the ship, where he found an AK-47 pointed at his forehead. For the next eight months, the crew were held hostage and tortured. In December 2010, the company paid \$5.5 million and Bahri returned to Delhi on January 7, 2011. Despite the trauma, he briefly returned to the sea, before dedicating himself to the International Seafarers Welfare and Assistance Network.

At sea, the weather can be treacherous. Speaking on condition of anonymity, a Master Mariner recalls that while loading in Greenland, they received a message that the ice was closing, which would have meant the ship remaining stuck on the shore for months. They swiftly sailed out only to hit an iceberg a few miles away. "As water started to pour inside, the entire crew was on deck trying to stop that. The nearest port was a day away. We managed to reach there, but every one aged 10 years that one day," he says.

Navigating war zones

As they factor in newer challenges, academies nationwide are rewriting their curricula, with safety training now covering how to navigate active war zones. At the 116-year-old TS Rehman, a mari-

time institute at Nhave near Mumbai, where close to 700 officers and Ratings (non-officers or hands-on operational, technical crew) train round the year, the routine has quietly shifted: for three months now, Saturday lectures have moved to war discussions.

"We discuss case studies from the war zone that shipping companies send us, update cadets on armed guards and their roles, how to mitigate risks, and on their insurance and medical cover. There's a psychologist on campus, and many of us on the faculty share our own experiences," says Captain Ashutosh Apankar, the principal.

Institutes also rely on simulation to prepare seafarers for drone and missile attacks. One scenario, for instance, simulates a Shahed-136 loitering munition attack at 2 am, giving the candidate 90 seconds to communicate the emergency, manage crew panic, and decide on evasive action, while biometrics track heart rate, eye movement, decision latency, and voice stress.

Companies are responding too. Maersk and others have introduced dedicated apps and WhatsApp groups to keep families updated when vessels enter affected areas or crew communications are paused for operational security.

The future of the ocean

While the demand for seafarers is rising, with India driving much of that growth, recruitment isn't keeping pace, says Captain Sanjay Parashar, former Master Mariner and CEO, VR Maritime Services Pvt. Ltd., which today manages crew for over 200 ships.

India has nearly 12,000 active captains against a demand of 25,000–40,000.

"The Merchant Navy offers extraordinary pay but demands physical presence, extended separation, and hardship far from land — things this generation is increasingly reluctant to give. Those still joining come either because they are passionate or are from smaller towns, where seafaring salaries still outweigh the pull of city life," says Parashar, who was also a member of the National Shipping Board.

Cadets start at salaries of around Rs 40,000 a month, junior engineers get around Rs 1 lakh. Within a decade, a senior officer earns Rs 10-15 lakh a month; at career peak, a Master or Chief Engineer commands Rs 10-20 lakh a month. Industry experts say LNG carriers, chemical tankers, and gas carriers pay the highest salaries.

The geography of Indian seafaring is equally revealing. Parashar says 90% of Ratings come from villages in Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand and coastal pockets near Rameshwaram in Tamil Nadu. "In households earning \$100 a month, a Rating's \$2,000 salary transforms not just one life but a whole family's standing," he says. Close to 50,000 Indians are employed on cruise or passenger ships annually, with a notable proportion of them women, particularly from Manipur.

As the number of Indian seafarers has increased more than five-fold over the past one-and-a-half decades, from 62,267 in 2010 to 3.07 lakh in 2024, the workforce composition has shifted distinctly towards non-officers, with more Ratings joining ships, according to data maintained by the Directorate General of Shipping.

But the profession hides a deeper, darker shadow. Seafarers desperate for work take contracts on vessels across West Africa and the Gulf, where ownership is deliberately opaque, with ships sailing under the dubious Flags of Convenience. When owners vanish and insurance lapses, Indian cadets are invariably the ones left stranded. India accounts for 18% of global seafarer abandonments or sailors being abandoned by ship owners.

Back in Lonavala, the light is fading over the ship's replica, steel catching the last of the sun. Inside, a drill is underway — alarms, instructions, the rehearsed choreography of calm under pressure.

In a few months, for cadets like Pacheco and Bharati, drills like this one will stop being simulations. The sea has always asked for courage, and now it is asking for some more.

With inputs from Purnima Sah, Mumbai, and Jay Mazoomdar, Delhi



ARUL HORIZON

INTERIM U.S.-IRAN ACCORD COULD BE SIGNED ON FRIDAY AT BURGENSTOCK RESORT IN SWITZERLAND

Trump: Iran deal to be public soon, it'll rule out n-weapons for Tehran

Deal allows Tehran to immediately begin selling oil and fuel: US official

Reuters
Evian, (France) Dubai, Jerusalem, June 16

DETAILS BEGAN to emerge on Tuesday of the US and Iran's interim deal to end the war in West Asia, with President Donald Trump saying it will rule out a nuclear weapon for Tehran and a US official saying it allows Iran to sell oil upon signing.

The interim deal is set to extend a tenuous ceasefire announced in April by another 60 days and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, which Iran has effectively blocked since the US and Israel attacked Iran in February.

The US President said the text of the deal states clearly that Tehran will not have a nuclear weapon, and the full agreement would be made public in a formal setting in a few days. Speaking at the G7 meetings in France, Trump added that he liked the idea of sending the Iran deal to Congress for review, a request by some Republican lawmakers.

A senior US official said the deal allows Iran to immediately begin selling oil and fuel, and included banking, transportation and insurance services to facilitate the sales.

The official added the agreement has conditions. "Iran can only access any benefits of the MoU if they abide by all of the points they agreed to – including no nuclear weapon, neutralizing its enriched material, and not interfering with the free flow of navigation in the Strait."

Negotiators will address difficult issues like the future of

Iran's nuclear programme during the next phase of talks, which Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said would start in Switzerland on Friday after the signing of the framework deal.

Two other issues that Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu used to justify the war - ending Iran's support for regional armed proxies and curbing its missile programme - are not thought to be on the agenda for those negotiations.

"Iran wants to get it done," Trump told reporters about the next phase of negotiations with Iran. "They have to get back to business, and the relationship is now normalized, so I think it's going to go pretty quickly." Earlier he described the deal as "a wall to a nuclear weapon" for Iran.

US Vice President JD Vance and Iran's top negotiator Mohammad Baqer Ghalibafare expected to attend Friday's formal signing.

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian wrote on social media on Monday that the interim agreement was an "important step" toward stopping the fighting, but noted a final deal for a lasting truce "has yet to take shape". Vance told CNN that the signed memorandum was a "very general document".

Both sides say the Strait of Hormuz will be open from Friday. On Tuesday, Iranian state television reported operations to lift its maritime blockade, while stressing that vessels must still coordinate with Iran's Revolutionary Guards.



A man flashes a victory sign as he rides a motorcycle past a banner that reads "Thank You Iran" following a deal between the US and Iran, in the southern suburbs of Beirut, Lebanon, on Tuesday. REUTERS

Hidden naval mines might still stymie Gulf shipping after war

John Ismay & Nicholas Kulish
June 16

THE DEAL to reopen the Strait of Hormuz has raised hopes that "oil will flow on both ends," as President Donald Trump said Sunday, quickly easing an impending energy crisis.

But it might not be that simple. To restart ship traffic in the strait, one of the most important questions will be whether the Iranians laid naval mines and, if so, how quickly they can be found and neutralized.

It is not even clear that the Iranians laid any mines at all; scores of ships have passed through the strait during the war without hitting mines. In March, United States Central

Command said that it had attacked 16 Iranian mine-laying vessels near the Strait of Hormuz, but the impact of those efforts is uncertain.

On Monday, Trump said that the strait was "already partially opened" and that "they're doing a little hunting for a couple of mines." He is also expected to ask European leaders to provide help clearing mines, saying it would not hurt to have "a ship or two up from a few countries."

Britain said last month that it could deploy mine-hunting drones as part of a multinational mission to secure the Strait. On Monday, President Emmanuel Macron said France was prepared to dispatch mine-clearing vessels if peace deal was confirmed. NYT

A \$300-billion 'fund' for Iran

Dubai: A \$300 billion private fund designed to trigger investment into Iran is outlined in the US-Iran framework agreement and more than half that sum has already been committed, a source told Reuters.

The new fund is a private investment vehicle, not a reconstruction or reparations program and will not include any government money or grants, the source said, adding that companies based in the US, the Gulf Arab states, Asia, South America and Africa have agreed to commit financing. REUTERS

Ebola cases in Congo rise to 837, Africa CDC warns of record spread

Reuters
Nairobi, June 16

THE NUMBER of confirmed Ebola cases in the Democratic Republic of Congo has increased to 837, including 196 deaths, government data showed on Tuesday. The number represented the total number of confirmed cases as of Monday, according to a situation report that documented 29 new cases and four new deaths in the previous 24 hours.

Meanwhile, the head of Africa's Centres for Disease Control and Prevention warned on Tuesday that the Ebola outbreak in Congo could be the worst ever, saying that it could cost billions of dollars to contain later if critical weaknesses in the response are not addressed quickly.

"If we don't stop the outbreak very soon it will be worse than what we had in West Africa and eastern DRC," Africa CDC Director-General Jean Kaseya told a virtual meeting of African heads of state in Burundi.

His warning, which echoed a similar projection by the US CDC, referred to the outbreak that affected Guinea, Liberia and Sierra Leone in 2014 to 2016, which killed over 11,000 people, and a



Congolese healthcare workers attend a Ebola response training camp at a treatment centre in Bunia, DR Congo. FILE

less deadly 2018 outbreak.

A Red Cross official said separately on Tuesday that the Ebola epidemic in eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo had not yet peaked. "We are afraid that this could last one year to end this disease," Bruno Michon, operations manager for the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies, said.

Africa's CDC is seeking \$518 million for a joint plan with WHO aimed at containing the outbreak. "If we don't have it in the next four weeks, we will not ask again for \$500 million, we'll be asking about \$1.5 billion. It will be \$7.5 billion if delay," Kaseya said.

● A.I. SYSTEMS UNDER DEVELOPMENT CAN AUTONOMOUSLY IDENTIFY OBJECTS LIKE ENEMY VEHICLES AND EVEN SINGLE OUT PEOPLE — LIKE ENEMY SOLDIERS

How Ukraine uses AI to knock out deadly Russian drones

Maria Varenikova
June 16

AT A launch site deep in a pine forest in central Ukraine, five men in balaclavas removed a camouflage cover from a lightweight replica of a Russian-made Shahed drone. "Pull!" one man shouted, and the winged, triangular drone flew up over the trees.

Standing nearby was a miniature black rocket with four propellers. This was the PI-Sun Long, one of Ukraine's first interceptor drones powered by artificial intelligence. Trained to find and knock down Shahed-type aircraft, it, too, took off.

The PI-Sun reflects both the

Ukrainian military's embrace of AI and the rapid evolution of its defenses against Shaheds. Russia fires the drones — essentially flying bombs — into Ukrainian cities in relentless daily waves, destroying infrastructure, killing civilians and sowing terror.

Earlier in the war, Ukraine relied mostly on heavy machine guns, electronic warfare and occasionally missiles to bring down Shaheds. Last August, the Ukrainian military began to widely deploy interceptor drones piloted by humans, without AI.

Now, a major Ukrainian drone manufacturer, SkyFall, which conducted the recent test in the forest, says its interceptors



A Shahed drone replica is prepared for launch during training. NYT

have made dozens of AI-assisted strikes on Shahed-type drones since November, among thousands of interceptions overall.

The interceptor drones are

among a range of AI-powered weapons that have been deployed in recent months after being trained on the immense troves of data that the war has

produced.

These weapons include unmanned ground vehicles equipped with machine guns that use AI to help them quickly identify small quadcopters known as FPV drones, because of the first-person view they offer to remote pilots. AI is also used in so-called terminal guidance systems, in which a weapon locks onto a target in its final approach and completes its strike without further human intervention.

Many AI systems under development can autonomously identify objects like enemy vehicles. Some, in a more sensitive potential application, can single out people, like enemy soldiers. SkyFall is among those quietly testing people-targeting capabilities in Ukraine.

AI developers and Ukrainian leaders say they are aware of the risks as the war spawns a technological revolution. As an era of fully autonomous lethal weapons approaches, human rights groups say reducing life-or-death decisions to an algorithmic calculation is a threat to humanity. At the same time, Ukraine is eager to use any technology that can increase its interception rate against Shaheds, and that means turning to highly automated air defenses.

As of now, AI does only part of the work. Humans remain involved in critical aspects. NYT

FRIDGES, ACs ARE AMONG 9 ITEMS THAT MAKE UP JUST 1% OF ENTIRE CPI BASKET OF GOODS & SERVICES

The memory chip problem that is slowly feeding into inflation

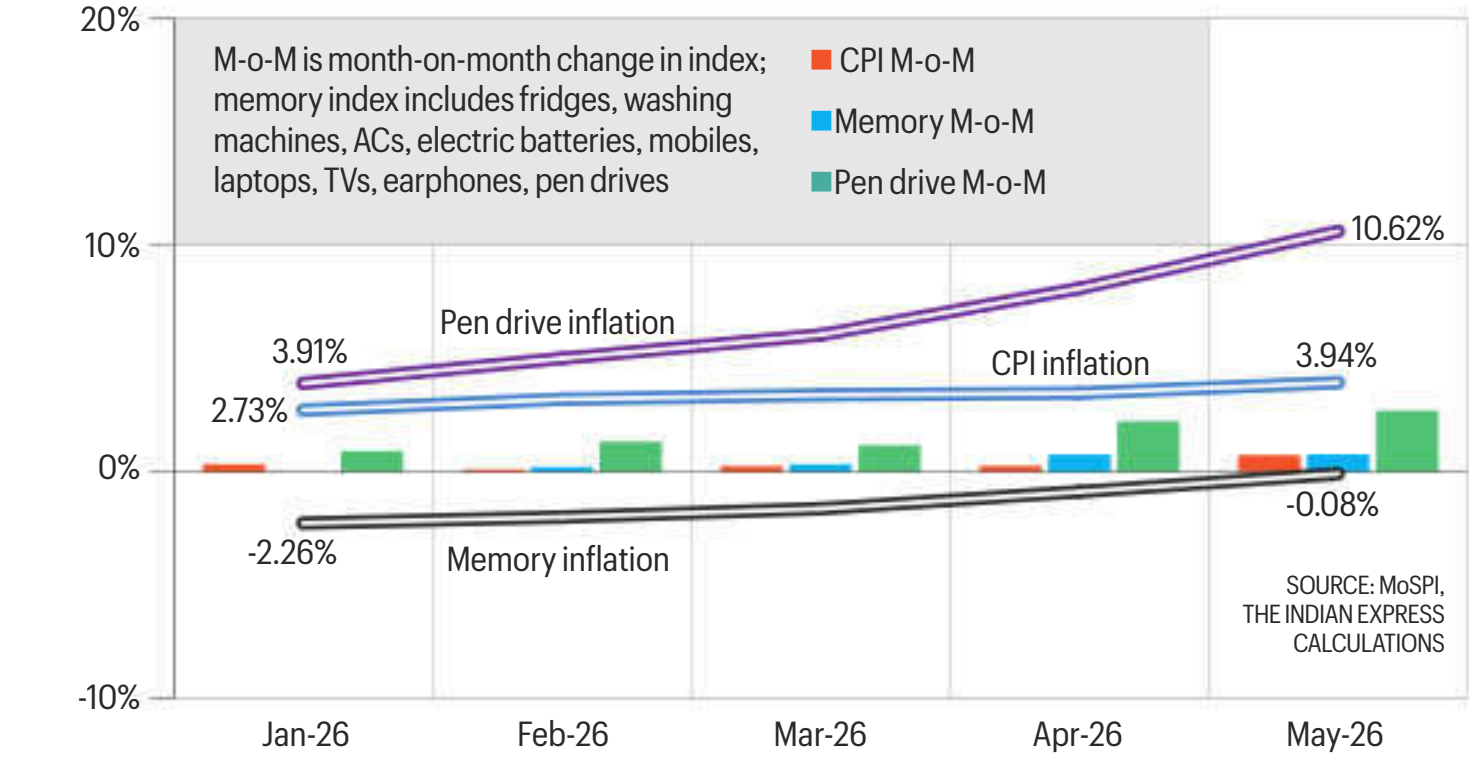
Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, June 16

FRIDGES, WASHING machines, air conditioners, electric batteries, smartphones, laptops, televisions, earphones, and... pen drives — over the last few months, each of these items have seen their prices rise from one month to the next, to varying degrees, all because of one minuscule component that is common to them all: memory chips. Together, these nine items make up just 1% of India's entire Consumer Price Index (CPI) basket of goods and services. But they are increasingly exerting upward pressure on headline retail inflation and may continue to do so for years.

The global investment boom in artificial intelligence (AI) has led to key chip suppliers such as TSMC, Samsung, and SK Hynix experiencing unprecedented growth over the last year.

What it has also done is pushed these manufacturers to make the more in-demand and advanced chips used in data centres sprouting up all over the world. What is being sacrificed are DRAM (Dynamic Random Access Memory) and other chips used in everyday electronics goods such as refrigerators, washing machines, ACs, smartphones, laptops, TVs, and earphones. The result of the supply shortage of the chips essential to consumer electronics is a mass-

● Risk to inflation in India from global AI super-cycle



ive rise in their prices. And electronics manufacturers are now passing on these higher chip prices to consumers so much so that it's even reflecting in the country's headline retail inflation data.

Memory inflation

In May, the price index for laptops, computers, and tablets was up month-on-month for the seventh month in a row. For mobiles, it was six months; for fridges, washing machines, and TVs, it was four months. And three months in a row for ACs, electric batteries, and headphones and earphones.

But the largest and longest sequential price rise has been for pen drives and hard disks.

Pure memory storage devices, the price index of this category has risen sequentially in 15 of the last 16 months — the period covered by the new CPI series with 2023-24 as the base year. The inflation impact of the price increases announced by phone and other electronic goods manufacturers has not been very high. But month-on-month increases in the price indices of refrigerators, washing machines, ACs, phones, PCs, and TVs are either already at 1% or approaching it. The figure

for pen drives and hard disks is nearing 3%. Policymakers across the world are already taking note of this new source of inflation.

Last month, economists from the Federal Reserve wrote of the "unprecedented contribution" to core inflation by the rapid price increases seen in the "Computer Software and Accessories" category of the US's Personal Consumption Expenditures price index.

A structural shortage

In India, the contribution to inflation of the nine items mentioned above has been rather small, partially because they

only make up 1% of the entire CPI basket; compare that with the three TOP vegetables (tomato, onion, potato) that account for nearly 2% of the CPI. Moreover, electronics manufacturers don't pass on higher input prices as quickly and substantially as farmers. Why? Because manufacturers already have a substantial profit margin built into the final price. However, the price increases announced so far are already hurting sales.

The India problem

As it turns out, not all buyers may be locking in long-term deals. Sumit Sadana, executive vice-president and chief business officer at Micron, told a media outlet last month that the US chip manufacturer's Indian customers were probably not understanding the gravity of the situation. He said that in terms of long-term demand, it was difficult to get "reliable signals" from Indian customers and what the company needed at this point was a "commitment" to such demand and not just an indication. The prospects for consumer electronics prices — and retail inflation — for Indians are not bright, then. The RBI currently expects CPI inflation to average 5.9% in the final three months of 2026. By then, the contribution to inflation from these electronics goods may be much higher. **FULL REPORT ON** WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

RBI relaxes ECLGS 5.0 norms

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, June 16

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) on Tuesday allowed banks and other regulated entities to assign a 0% risk weight on 75% of the eligible guaranteed exposure under the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS) 5.0, easing the capital treatment for such loans, it said in a notification.

"Exposures guaranteed under the ECLGS 5.0 shall attract risk weight of zero percent to the extent of 75% of the guaranteed portion, i.e., to the extent of guaranteed portion wherein the settlement amount is expected to be received within thirty days from the date of invocation. The re-

As of June 10, more than 1.06 lakh loans worth over Rs 48,484 crore had been guaranteed under ECLGS 5.0, with 96% of the guarantees extended to MSMEs

maining exposure shall attract risk weight as per the extant guidelines," the notification said.

The central bank amended the capital adequacy norms for scheduled commercial banks, all-India financial institutions, small finance banks, regional rural banks,

urban cooperative banks and non-banking financial companies.

The move follows the government's introduction of ECLGS 5.0 in May to provide guaranteed credit support to sectors such as — micro, small and medium enterprises (MSME), non-MSMEs and airline sector — facing liquidity challenges arising from the prevailing external geopolitical situation.

According to the Department of Financial Services, the scheme has crossed the one lakh guarantee mark in just over a month.

As of June 10, more than 1.06 lakh loans worth over Rs 48,484 crore had been guaranteed under ECLGS 5.0, with 96% of the guarantees extended to MSMEs. FE